

PROPOSAL

THIRD PARTY EVALUATION OF THE INITIATIVE FOR INCREASING EFFICIENCY IN DECISION MAKING -GOVERNMENT OF MAHARASHTRA



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I. INTRODUCTION

The Department of Administrative Reforms and Public Grievances (DARPG), is the nodal agency of the Government of India in-charge of policy making, monitoring and coordinating departments for public grievances and administrative reforms.

The honourable Prime Minister has directed all Government Ministries/Departments to increase efficiency in decision making as part of administrative reforms. To this effect, a national workshop on 'Increasing Efficiency in Decision Making' for all Ministries/ Departments was convened by the DARPG under the chairmanship of the Cabinet Secretary on March 26, 2021

The objective of the workshop was to ensure the implementation of the following recommendations emanating from the discussions of the group of Secretaries under the chairmanship of the Cabinet Secretary:

- Classification of subject, identification of file movement paths for each category of subjects indicating origin and destination
- Review and updation of delegation of powers
- Strengthening of the Central Registry Unit to minimize delay at receipt distribution, fortnightly review of pendency of files/ receipts
- Migration to e-office 7.0, extension of e-office to attached and subordinate offices/autonomous offices/ organizations

In pursuance of the deliberations in the National Workshop, the Secretary, DARPG issued follow up letters to all ministries/departments with the request that they may draw-up a roadmap for increasing efficiency in decision making. In October 2021, DARPG published the Impact Analysis Report based on the inputs received from the Ministries/Departments.

In February – March 2022, a third-party evaluation was conducted by Quality Council of India based on the assessment visits to the Ministries/Departments followed by a detailed report 'Initiatives for Increasing Efficiency in Decision Making in the Central Secretariat'.

General Administration Department is an administrative department of the Maharashtra Government, and it has sub-divisions like General Public Sub-Department, Common Development Authority and such sub sections. The Chief Minister is the minister in charge of the General Administration Department. The department's mandate includes Internal Ethics, Design and Implementation, Special Projects (Mumbai Development and General Development), Special Investigations and technology. The department remains committed to provide the related services to the citizens in a prompt, courteous and dignified manner.

Efficient Decision making is fundamental to a responsive and accountable government. Accelerating the pace and efficiency of decision making is crucial for economic growth and enhancing the ease of living of citizens. Comprehensive review of levels of disposal, channels of submission and effective use of technology is needed for enhancing efficiency in decision making. Thus, the General administration Department, Government of Maharashtra envisages to develop similar reports for the 40 departments and 35 districts of the State, as the 'Third Party Evaluation of Initiatives for Increasing Efficiency in Decision Making in the Central Secretariat'.

II. About QCI

2.1 The Quality Council of India (QCI) is an autonomous body set up by the Ministry of Commerce and Industry, Government of India jointly with the Indian Industry represented by the three premier industry associations viz. Associated Chambers of Commerce and Industry of India (ASSOCHAM), Confederation of Indian Industry (CII), and Federation of Indian Chambers of Commerce and Industry (FICCI). QCI was instituted with the objective to establish and operate a national accreditation structure and promote quality through National Quality Campaign.

2.2 The Council was established to provide a credible, reliable mechanism for third party assessment of products, services and processes which is accepted and recognized globally. It was envisaged that the Council will play the role of the National Accreditation Body (NAB) as per existing eco-system of quality around the world in accordance with the international best practices & standards and will ensure that the quality of life of citizens around the world is improved.

2.3 QCI plays a pivotal role in conducting a third-party assessment of products, services, and processes. Thereby, helping to propagate adoption and adherence to quality standards in all important spheres of activities including education, healthcare, environment protection, governance, social sectors, infrastructure sector, etc.

2.4 Being an independent organization concerned with quality, it is the responsibility of QCI to be an equal opportunity employer, gender-sensitive, and accountable to the public through RTI Act. Having stated that, QCI may be privy to certain information and not make them public, solely to maintain information confidentiality for stakeholders.

III. Key Projects

QCI's stellar record of accomplishment and reputation demonstrates its competence and capabilities across industries. QCI has partnered in various projects of the Central ministries and State Governments and has played a critical role in creating an ecosystem for quality. Followings are some of the key projects we have taken up in the past.

3.1 Open Network for Digital Commerce (ONDC)

QCI was appointed as the Program Management Unit (PMU) by the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT), Ministry of Commerce and Industry, to enable the development and adoption of ONDC. As a part of the scale-up plan, QCI undertook further activities necessary for the national rollout. QCI had undertaken additional requirements and activities of the accelerated ONDC national rollout and established ONDC as a Section 8 entity.

QCI had helped in onboarding new and potential network participants while preparing for the soft launch of the initiative. The initiative is being steered independently by the ONDC company and QCI continues to remain as a founding shareholder in the Board of ONDC.

3.2 Performance Rating of Concession, Contractors & Consultants (MoRTH)

The Ministry of Road Transport & Highways engaged QCI to prepare a robust and objective assessment framework. In order to formulate the performance rating framework and methodology, extensive research was conducted. Codes and standards were studied, international performance rating models were reviewed, and sector experts were consulted. QCI developed a performance-based rating mechanism for key vendors engaged in the highway development process. Customized rating frameworks were developed according to different modes of implementation and stage of progress. The frameworks provide a holistic assessment of vendor performance and evaluate vendors on parameters like quality of construction, timely submission of progress reports and audit reports, adherence to guidelines and IRC codes, compliance with industry standards and specifications and overall process management. The vendors are required to submit documentary evidence in support of their claims. Information was also corroborated with supporting vendors.

3.3 Ranking of Jails in Haryana State

The Hon'ble Chief Minister of Haryana proposed developing a system for ranking Haryana jails based on various parameters such as security, cleanliness, greenery, medical facilities, food, reform, skill development facilities, and so on, to ensure that the jails are being maintained properly as per the rules and norms on a regular basis. QCI is conducting the assessment of 20 central or district jails in Haryana state for the calendar year 2022 to validate the above-mentioned parameters. The ranking of jails had been conceptualized to ensure that the jail management is working to maintain an efficient and effective system and to assess the conditions of the jails as well as analyse the conditions in which the inmates are being held.

3.4 Swachh Survekshan 2021 - Ministry of Housing & Urban Affairs

Swachh Survekshan is an annual survey of cleanliness, hygiene, and sanitation in cities and towns across India. It was launched as part of the Swachh Bharat Abhiyan, which aimed to make India clean and free of open defecation by October 2, 2019. The objective of the survey was to encourage large-scale citizen engagement/participation, ensure sustainability of initiatives taken towards garbage-free and open defecation-free cities, provide credible outcomes, which would be validated by third-party certification, and institutionalize existing systems through online processes, creating awareness among all sections of society about the importance of working together to make towns and cities more habitable and sustainable.

3.5 National Award on e-Governance, 2022 - DARPG

National Awards for e-Governance (NAeG) are presented every year to recognize and promote excellence in implementation of e-Governance initiatives in the National Conference on e-Governance (NCeG).

QCI Setup a PMU to develop the methodology, assessment framework and subsequently score and shortlist the applications of e-Governance initiatives received from Central Ministries/Departments, State/UT Governments, Districts, Local Bodies, Central & State Government Public Sector Undertakings (PSUs), Academic/Research Institutions (Government and Non - Government) for National e-Governance Awards 2021-22.

3.6 CPGRAMS Reforms - DARPG

CPGRAMS is a e-Service delivery portal for grievances related to all Central Ministries/Departments and State Governments. The objective of the project was to develop a robust system for grievance redressal with features like auto-forwarding grievance to the last mile officer, user-friendly categorisation for easy filing of grievance, and asking specific information from the citizen for the PG Officer to effectively resolve a grievance through the CPGRAMS Portal. This has led to reduction in redressal time, improvement in quality of redressal and multi-fold increase in mapping of PG officers on the portal.

3.6 Swachhata Assessment of Special Campaign - DARPG

In October 2021 & 2022, QCI assisted DARPG as a Third Party Evaluator for Special Campaign on cleanliness, conducting physical inspection and qualitative assessment of 84 Ministries. The Special Campaign involved initiatives like discarding redundant scrap material and obsolete items to improve cleanliness at workplaces. The Assessment also included identifying best practices across ministries for replication.

IV. Impact Evaluation of Initiatives for Increasing Efficiency

The Initiative for Increasing Efficiency in Decision Making consisted of 4 inter-linked components, namely

- a. Delayering: Ministries/Departments ensure that levels in a channel of submission do not exceed four and review instructions on levels of disposal
- b. Delegation: Ensuring delegation of powers within Ministries/Departments for speedier decision making
- c. Desk Officer System: Operationalization of the Desk Officer system to convert the administration into an officer-oriented system
- d. Digitization: Digitization of Central Registration Units and adoption of e-office 7.

QCI conducted a Third Party Impact Evaluation of the Initiatives for Increasing Efficiency in Decision Making in the Central Secretariat, across all the Central Ministries/Departments. The following were the key findings:

- Reforms of delayering, delegation, digitization and desk officer system have led to defined work allocation, reduced channels of submission and timely decision making, embodying the principle of “Minimum Government, Maximum Governance”
- Channels of submission have been revised in 76 ministries/departments and restricted to 4 or below. The successful implementation of delayering has resulted in flatter and agile organisational structure of the ministries/ departments by reducing the channels of submission
- Files are initiated at SO/US level for the majority of the subjects and disposed off within 3-4 levels
- 72 ministries/departments have delegated financial as well as administrative (disposal) powers to the heads of the divisions and subordinate officers for routine and petty transactions. The financial powers vested in the ministry/ department have been delegated to Head of the Department (JS level) and Head of the Office (US Level) for incurring contingency and miscellaneous expenditure
- Desk officer system has been operational in 28 ministries expediting the movement and disposal of files. The desk officer system has streamlined the functioning under clear work allocation in the ministries/departments
- Designated desk officers operate having specific work assigned with a defined sub-function or activity in their charge
- Implementation of e-office has resulted in reduction of paper and stationary usage. Ministry of Railways and Department of Chemicals and Petrochemicals conducted a comparative study to measure the reduction in stationary usage before and after the implementation of e-office. Their study showed that 2x (approximately) reduction of stationary usage after e-office implementation

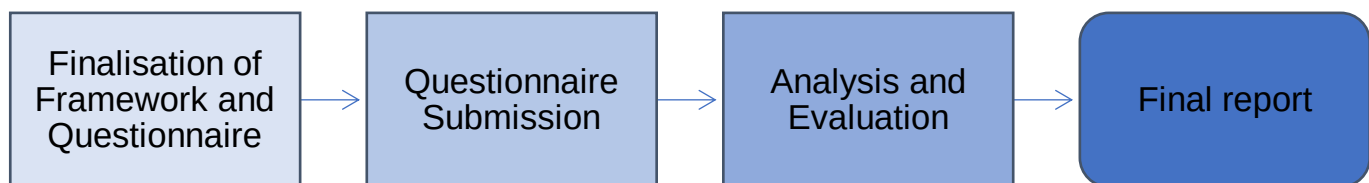
V. Objective

The overall vision is to adopt flatter organizational structures and put in place appropriate delegation at various levels to make governance more responsive, accountable, and transparent. For this purpose, current practices and procedural frameworks, levels of disposal, channels of submission and existing delegation are to be reviewed. After due deliberation, a four-pronged approach was identified, consisting of Delayering, Delegation, Desk Officer System and Digitization.

The objective of this study is to evaluate the administration in the Government of Maharashtra Secretariat and Districts, through four-pronged approach. Specifically, this study seeks to:

- i) To provide a comparative analysis within departments and between districts
- ii) Examine and evaluate the consequences of these measures on overall functioning and work productivity of the departments, their organizational hierarchy, effectiveness, and culture
- iii) Verify and quantify the financial and other benefits accrued to the Ministries/Departments and the government from the operationalization of these administrative reforms
- iv) Identify best practices across departments and districts
- v) To provide an overall view of the efficiency enhancement, challenges faced and future, prospects, in the working of the departments and the districts.

VI. Plan of Action



4.1 Finalisation of Framework and Questionnaire

The base questionnaire and Terms of Reference will be the one used by QCI in the exercise conducted for DARPG (Attached in the Annexure). The team will be researching and studying the Manual of Office Procedure of the Government of Maharashtra and will accordingly update the questionnaires keeping in mind 2 base units: Department and District

4.2 Questionnaire Submission

A qualitative study to be conducted for all the participating departments and districts to augment the secondary research and address the objectives of the study mentioned above. The primary tool to be used for this study will be the Questionnaire developed by QCI. The Questionnaire will have a four-section approach to incorporate the four components i.e Delegation, Delaying, Desk Officer System, Digitization. The quantitative aspect of the study will also be gauged through varying questions in the questionnaire to numerically reach the outcome of the exercise. This stage will include 2 steps:

1. The QCI team will be sharing the questionnaires along with the data and documents required with the 40 Departments and 35 Districts of the Government of Maharashtra. The departments and the districts will be required to fill the questionnaire and submit to QCI.
2. The QCI team may visit or interact through VC with the different Departments and Districts to understand and augment their respective responses to the questionnaires.

4.3 Analysis and Evaluation

- Assessment of Documents (Circulars, Meetings, Stakeholder Interaction, Presentations, Financials, Photographs) for ratification would form a part of the exercise.
- Analysis and collation of the responses to the questionnaires to draw relevant insights for the objective of this study
- Clarifications, if any, from the Departments and Districts on the questionnaire and data/documents submitted

4.4 Submission of Final Report

The final reports will be in 2 parts: 1. Department-wise 2. District-wise

The reports are envisaged to highlight the overall findings for the Government of Maharashtra, along with the comparative analysis, best practices and areas of improvement.

VII. INDICATIVE TIMELINE

Activity	Timeline (Weeks)			
	1	2 - 4	5 - 6	7 - 8
Finalisation of Framework and Questionnaire				
Questionnaire Submission				
Analysis and Evaluation				
Submission of Final Report				

ANNEXURE

Terms of Reference

Impact Evaluation of Initiative for Increasing Efficiency in Decision Making in the Central Secretariat

1. Introduction

- 1.1. The Department of Administrative Reforms and Public Grievances (DARPG), under the Ministry of Personnel, Public Grievances and Pensions is the nodal agency for administrative reforms and redressal of public grievances. In its capacity as the agency responsible for administrative reforms, it has undertaken several reform initiatives, including those geared towards reduction in paperwork, layers of bureaucracy with the aim of improving operational efficiency, delegating powers and enhancing informed decision making.
- 1.2. One such reform undertaken by DARPG in this regard is the launch of the 'Initiative for Increasing Efficiency in Decision-making in the Central Secretariat' pursuant to the recommendations of the Second Administrative Reforms Commission in its 13th Report. This initiative is an administrative reform that seeks to promote the use of technology, provide for adequate delegation in decision making levels with the goal of cutting delays in file processing, and creating a flatter Government structure.
- 1.3. The Initiative for Increasing Efficiency in Decision Making consists of 4 inter-linked components, namely
 - a. Delaying: Ministries ensure that levels in a channel of submission do not exceed four and review instructions on levels of disposal
 - b. Delegation: Ensuring delegation of powers within Ministries/Departments as well as autonomous institutions/CPSUs for speedier decision making
 - c. Desk Officer System: Operationalization of the Desk Officer system to convert the Central Secretariat to an officer-oriented system
 - d. Digitization: Digitization of Central Registration Units and adoption of e-office 7.0

2. Objectives and Evaluation Framework

2.1. Objectives of the Study

The objective of this study is to understand the impact of the four-pronged approach taken for administrative reforms under the Initiative for Increasing Efficiency in Decision-making in the Central Secretariat. Specifically, this study seeks to :

- i. To provide a comparative analysis of the before- and after- scenario following the adoption of the four-pronged administrative reforms
- ii. Examine and evaluate the consequences of these measures on overall functioning and work productivity of the Ministries/Departments, their organizational hierarchy, effectiveness and culture

- iii. Verify and quantify the financial and other benefits accrued to the Ministries/Departments and the government from the operationalization of these administrative reforms
- iv. Identify best practices across ministries and departments
- v. To provide an overall view of the efficiency enhancement, challenges faced and future prospects, in the working of ministries and department.

3. Impact Evaluation

3.1. Secondary Research Methodology

Action Taken Reports from ministries and departments will be examined and based on this further evaluation may be carried out while conducting the primary research. Assessment of Documents (Circulars, Meetings, Stakeholder Interaction, Presentations, Financials, Photographs) for ratification would form a part of the exercise.

3.2. Primary Research Methodology

A qualitative study be conducted for all the participating ministries to augment the secondary research and address the objectives of the study mentioned above. The primary tool to be used for this study will be the Questionnaire developed by Quality Council of India (QCI) as the Third Party Government Verification Agency (TPGVA). The Questionnaire will have a four section approach to incorporate the four components for the Initiative. The quantitative aspect of the study will also be gauged through varying questions in the questionnaire to numerically reach the outcome of the exercise.

- 3.3. Out of 84 M/Ds, over 70 Ministries and Departments have implemented these administrative reforms, and documented the change that this initiative had created. It will be imperative to interview the concerned officers in each of the Ministries/Departments.

4. Deliverables & Timelines

- 4.1. A robust process for quality control needs to be followed during data collection. The following aspects shall be carried out:
 - a. Planning Process may be carried out from 1st February, 2022 to 28th February, 2022 whereby the Questionnaire with proper scrutiny will be formulated. The process with guidance from DARPG will be understood. QCI will work closely with the DARPG. The Action Taken Reports will be studied, the schedules for the evaluation will be planned and prepared. Communication and coordination with over 70 ministries and departments regarding the evaluation exercise may be carried out.
 - b. The physical impact evaluation exercise may then be undertaken from the 1st March, 2022 to 31st March, 2022. Where, seven teams of two QCI personnel each, will be deployed to undertake the exercise across various ministries and departments.

- c. QCI may conduct a few interviews face to face. In the event of non-availability of respondent or complications due to the ongoing pandemic, on a case-to-case basis permission may be provided for online/virtual interviews.
- d. Final Evaluation Report and presentation after incorporation of inputs from all the concerned stakeholders may be collated after the completion of the impact evaluation physical exercise. All the study outputs including primary data shall be compiled, classified and submitted by QCI to DARPG in soft form apart from the report

**Initiative for Increasing Efficiency in Decision-making in the Central
Secretariat**

Date:	
Name of the Ministry:	
Location:	
Name and Designation of the officer-in-charge:	

General

S.No.	Particulars	Response
1.	Has the ministry/department conducted any assessment study to measure the impact of initiatives taken to increase the effectiveness of decision-making? (Data and associated docs if conducted)	• Yes • No

A. DELAYERING

S. No.	Levels of Disposal and Channels of Submission	Responses
1.	Has the process of layering (reduction in channels of submission) been carried out in your ministry/department?	• Yes ○ Completely ○ Partially, specify details • No ○ Revision under process ○ Other reasons
2.	Based on which of the following criterion did the ministry/department undertake layering reforms? Give list of Channels of Submission division/subject wise. Give list of total no of divisions.	• Subject of disposal • Division-wise • Both • Others, specify

3.	What is the level of file initiation for the following?	● Administrative ○ Enumerate list(US, DS, etc.) ● Financial ○ Enumerate list(US, DS, etc.) ● Parliamentary Starred/Unstarred question ● RTI ● Policy Matters ● Others (Specify division/subject wise)
4.	Are there multiple officers in a particular channel/level?	● Yes, Elaborate ● No
5.	Is information on channels of submission of cases (other than the classified ones) available on your website?	● Yes ● No ● Partially
6.	Are the details (such as name, telephone, e-mail id) of officers- in-charge (of particular division or subject matter) mentioned on the website?	● Yes ● Partially ● No o Specify Reason
7.	Has review of cadres and personnel been conducted?	● Yes, Before Delayering ● Yes, After Delayering ● Both ● Partially ● No
8.	Is there a regular review provision/mandate?	● Yes ● No
9.	Do you notice any reduction in the time taken in movement of the file system and its disposal?	● Yes, Specify ● No

10.	Has there been any other impact of the Delaying Reforms?	(Descriptive)
11.	List any challenges/bottlenecks after undertaking the Delaying reforms.	(Descriptive)
12.	List any other initiatives/best practice, if undertaken.	(Descriptive)

B. DELEGATION

S.No.	Flattening Organisational Structure	Responses
1.	Has there been an increase in administrative delegation of powers?(subject/division wise approving authorities)	• Yes - o Enumerate the delegated financial powers- division/subject-wise • Partially, specify details • No
2.	Have the financial powers been delegated?	• Yes - o Enumerate the delegated financial powers- division/subject-wise • Partially, specify details • No
3.	Has there been a decrease in time taken for decision making due to delegation in that particular division/subject matter?	• Yes. Eg, - o Tendering process has been sped up - o File movement - o Grievance Redressal - o Others, elaborate • No
4.	Has there been any other impact of the Delegation Reforms?	(Descriptive)

5.	List the bottlenecks/challenges with Delegation reforms undertaken?	(Descriptive)
6.	List any other initiatives/best practices, if undertaken.	(Descriptive)

C. DESK OFFICER SYSTEM

S.No.	Effective Use of Desk Officer System:	Responses
1.	Does the department use Desk Officer System?	• Yes • Partially • No, specify reason
2.	Specify the name of divisions/subjects with a desk officer.	(Name and Number)
3.	Is there clear work allocation/mandate specified for each desk officer? (Show Order/Circular)	• Yes • Partially • No, specify reason
4.	Which of the following aspects of work have shown increased efficiency after the implementation of the desk office system?(General Impact of Desk Officer)	Please Specify, • Reduction in time, specify process • Process streamlined • Others, specify
5.	Have the desk officers been trained for effective discharge of their work?	• Yes • No • Partially
6.	Has there been any other impact of the Desk Officer Reforms?	(Descriptive)
7.	List the bottlenecks/challenges with Desk Officer reforms undertaken?	(Descriptive)

8.	List any other initiatives/best practices, if undertaken.	(Descriptive)
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D. DIGITIZATION

D.	Technology Adoptions - Optimizing e-Office Platform	Responses
1.	Which version of e-office is currently being used?	(Specify)
2.	Is e-office accessible to all departmental employees?	• Yes • Partially • No
3.	Specify the number of digital signatures issued to employees within the department/ministry	- Open ended
4.	Does the ministry/department have adequate number of laptops/desktops, scanners, printers, and webcams? (Data on number of scanners, laptops, printers and webcams)	• Yes • No
5.	What is the process of handling/sharing of e-files for inter-ministerial communications?	- Open ended
6.	Has Capacity Building for the staff for using e-office been conducted?	• Yes ○ Professionals/Experts from outside ○ In-house training • Partially • No
7.	Is tracking of files done to measure the number of days of file disposal?	• Yes • Partially • No

8.	Are there any technological/digital initiatives to increase working efficiency?	- Open ended
9.	Specify number of VPNs issued, if any.	(Specify Number)
10.	Number of e-files created. (Year wise for Fin Year 2019,2020 and month wise for financial year 2021)	- (Data)
11.	Has e-office led to reduction in stationery use? (paper, etc)	• Yes, specify data and process • No
12.	Has digitization reforms/e-office led to financial savings?	• Yes, specify data and process • No
13.	How has digitization helped in increasing efficiency in decision making?	• Reduction in time taken in decision making/disposal of files • Streamlining of the process • Ease of use by employees • Others, Specify (Descriptive)
14.	Has there been any other impact of the Digitization Reforms?	- Open ended
15.	List the bottlenecks/challenges with Digitization reforms taken?	- Open ended
16.	List any other initiatives/best practices, if undertaken.	- Open ended

E. Central Registration Unit

S.No.	Questions	Responses
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1.	Has the CRU been digitised?	• Yes • No • Partially
2.	Total number of physical and digital receipts being handled by the department/ministry (Data of files handled from FY 2019-20 and FY 2020-21 and monthly data till 28 th of feb for FY 2021-22)	- Open ended
3.	How many of the physical files handled between the below specified period are of non-classified nature? (Data of files handled from FY 2019-20 and FY 2020-21 and monthly data till 28 th of feb for FY 2021-22)	- Open ended
4.	Has there been a reduction in handling of physical files since digitisation of CRU? (Data of files handled from FY 2019-20 and FY 2020-21 and monthly data till 28 th of feb for FY 2021-22)	• Yes • No
5.	Number of scanners available at the CRU	- Open ended
6.	What is the process of handling e-mail receipts?	- Open ended